

◀ KANGNA RANAUT, 38

| BJP | *Mandi, Himachal Pradesh*

Plenty of cherubs with apple cheeks float around in Himachal's Edenic orchards. None has been bequeathed with such a devastating Avenging Angel equipage as to constitute a one-woman army: a sharp-bladed, undulating tongue, a wasp-like sting and the will to vanquish foes with vials of venom. Kangna Ranaut had always exhibited signs of being as outspoken, self-governed and resolute a person in real life as her characters were in her breakout films *Queen* (2014) and *Tanu Weds Manu* (2015). That success had come after the gritty passage that awaits every newcomer to Bollywood, and its core of feminist autonomy and anti-establishment rage could just as well have yielded a different kind of politics—before she chose to morph into a Joan of Arc for the Hindu right, with even films being conceived of as custom-built vehicles for that cause. Not that she needed it. She could raise heat and dust all on her own—as demonstrated by eight legal cases, including those for "outraging religious feelings" and "promoting enmity between different groups of religion". Nor did the poll campaign soften her: "Mandi's *beti*" rode on personal attacks on rivals, besides enthusiastic cheerleading for Modidom.

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If you're the sort whose attentions are drawn to the bevy of entertainers coming in to lighten the gloom of politics, no contest could've been more compelling than the Double Bill of Hooghly: Rachna Banerjee, a former Miss Kolkata who shared screenspace with Amitabh Bachchan in *Sooryavansham*, versus actress Locket Chatterjee. Banerjee and Chatterjee have co-starred before: in films like *Chaoya Paoya*, *Paribar* and *Tyag*. They're well-matched in height—around 163-164 cm—but Banerjee stood taller in this round. Thanks to the other Banerjee who once guested on *Didi No.1*, the TV show she hosts. Need we spell out the name?



▲ RACHNA BANERJEE, *51*

| TMC | *Hooghly, West Bengal*



◀ JUNE MALIAH, *54*

| TMC | *Medinipur, West Bengal*

The name almost invites the playful punster, and even her long-time friend couldn't quite resist the temptation. "They will say bye to June in June," said Agnimitra Paul, fashion designer and fellow traveller from the world of glitz to the gut-busting inferno that Bengal politics can often be—where, as it happened, she was her pal's BJP rival for an LS seat. But Medinipur chose to say a bigger hello to the Trinamool actress-politician with a winning smile and wise eyes. The eponymous assembly seat had already sanctified her with a debut win in 2021. Her cinematic debut had been equally worthy—the critically acclaimed *Lathi* (1996). A decade later came *The Bong Connection*. In Bollywood hit *Meri Pyari Bindu*, she played Parineeti Chopra's mother. In life, she was a single mother to a son and daughter for years (before a second marriage in 2019) and kept her filmography ticking through politics.